

NOT SAFE

09-001

This jar did not seal properly because it was not processed at the correct pressure or for the right amount of time. Without a good seal, bacteria can grow and produce dangerous toxins. Always follow tested recipes and maintain proper pressure for low-acid foods.

PREVENT

Use an accurate pressure canner with a tested recipe, vent for 10 minutes before pressurizing, maintain pressure consistently, and check seals after 24 hours. Reprocess or refrigerate unsealed jars immediately.

DISCARD

09-002

Tomatoes without added acid are not acidic enough for safe boiling water canning. The bulging lid and cloudy liquid indicate possible bacterial growth and gas formation. Such jars can be unsafe and must be discarded.

PREVENT

Always add lemon juice or citric acid when canning tomatoes in a water bath. Follow current research-based instructions for acidification.

NOT SAFE

09-003

Low-acid foods must be pressure canned to reach safe temperatures and kill botulism spores. Boiling water bath doesn't get hot enough to ensure safety even if the lid seals.

PREVENT

Use a pressure canner for all low-acid foods like vegetables and peppers. Follow tested recipes and correct times.

SAFE

09-004

Crystals are sugar precipitates and not harmful but indicate texture or recipe problems. Jam is safe but may have altered texture. Use precise recipes and sugar amounts to avoid.

PREVENT

Use tested recipes, dissolve sugar fully, and stir to prevent crystals when cooking jams.

DISCARD

09-005

Mold growth inside canned food is a clear sign of spoilage. Do not taste or consume as spoilage organisms may produce harmful toxins.

PREVENT

Use proper processing times with pressure canning for low-acid foods, ensure lids seal properly, and check jars before storage.

NOT SAFE

09-006

Headspace affects vacuum formation and food safety. Not enough liquid to cover food can lead to air pockets, spoilage, or improper sealing.

PREVENT

Follow recommended headspace for product (usually 1/2 inch for acid foods) and ensure food is covered by liquid before processing.

DISCARD

09-007

Leaking jars do not have proper vacuum seal and allow bacterial entry. Spoiled seafood can be highly dangerous, discard immediately.

PREVENT

Use new lids, clean jar rims, follow pressure canning guidelines, do not reuse damaged lids, and check seals after processing.

NOT SAFE

09-008

Low-acid foods like mushrooms require pressure canning to ensure safety. Water bath canning does not kill all bacteria that produce toxins.

PREVENT

Always pressure can low-acid foods like mushrooms. Follow tested USDA recipes and times.

SAFE

09-009

Floating fruit or vegetable pieces can indicate improper packing or headspace. It affects quality but not necessarily safety if processing was done correctly.

PREVENT

Pack jars according to recipe instructions, allow correct headspace, and remove air bubbles before processing.

NOT SAFE

09-010

Retightening lids after processing or residue on jar rims can cause poor seals, leading to spoilage and risk of unsafe food.

PREVENT

Do not retighten lids after processing. Clean jar rims well before filling and check seal after cooling.

SAFE

09-011

Floating fruit often happens when fruit is packed raw instead of hot. Raw fruit contains air in its cells that escapes and causes pieces to float during processing.

PREVENT

Use hot pack method by cooking fruit briefly before packing; this reduces air and prevents floating.

SAFE

09-012

Exposure to heat or prolonged processing can cause fruit to lose its bright color and become darker or dull.

PREVENT

Use recommended processing times and avoid overcooking fruit before packing.

SAFE

09-013

Excess sugar or incorrect sugar balance causes sugar crystals to form in jams. These crystals affect texture but do not mean the jam is spoiled.

PREVENT

Follow tested recipes exactly including sugar amounts and avoid doubling recipes mid-way.

SAFE

09-014

Cloudy brine can result from natural fermentation or minerals from ingredients. It's usually safe if no off odors or spoilage signs are present.

PREVENT

Use clean jars, hot pack, and follow recipe recommendations for processing and brine ingredients.

SAFE

09-015

Siphoning causes juice or liquid loss from jars due to rapid temperature/pressure change. It reduces quality but is usually safe if sealed.

PREVENT

Wait 5-10 minutes after processing before removing jars; leave adequate headspace; avoid rapid cooling.

SAFE

09-016

Packing fruit loosely or failing to remove trapped air causes floating fruit pieces during canning.

PREVENT

Pack fruit firmly and remove air bubbles with a utensil before sealing.

SAFE

09-017

Liquid separation in jams occurs when there is not enough pectin or cooking time was too short to form a stable gel.

PREVENT

Follow tested recipes and pectin instructions carefully; cook jam to proper gel point.

SAFE

09-018

Liquid siphoning or wrong headspace means food is not fully covered, which can reduce quality and cause discoloration but is safe if sealed.

PREVENT

Leave correct headspace and wait recommended time before removing jars from canner.